

L'Omer or B'Omer?

Ten Minute Halacha ♦ Rav Aryeh Lebowitz

Every Lag BaOmer, millions of Jews say the words *Lag BaOmer*. And yet the Mechaber — the Shulchan Aruch — writes *Lag LaOmer*. This almost-unnoticed discrepancy opens one of the most elegant halachic debates in the Omer period: does the Omer count refer to what is already in the past (*LaOmer*) or what is present right now (*BaOmer*)? The answer, as Rav Lebowitz shows, touches on whether sefirah today is min haTorah or mideRabbanan, whether each day is its own mitzvah or part of one continuous unit, and what kind of zecher we are performing when we count.

The Question Nobody Asked

לְעוֹמֶר אוֹ בְּעוֹמֶר?

“LaOmer or BaOmer?”

The foundational question of this shiur

Nobody calls it Lag LaOmer. Yet that is precisely what the Mechaber writes in Shulchan Aruch (Orach Chaim 493:2): *nohagin shelo lehisaper ad Lag LaOmer*. Not BaOmer — LaOmer.

The difference in a single letter turns out to carry enormous weight. *BaOmer* means *in the Omer* — present tense. *LaOmer* means *to the Omer* or *in connection with the Omer* — retrospective, referring to the Omer brought the day before.

Rav Lebowitz frames this not merely as a grammatical question but as a window into what sefirat haOmer actually is. Are we counting the Omer we brought today? Or are we counting toward a future goal? The language we use reflects a deep theological position about the nature of the mitzvah.

“The Mechaber writes LaOmer. Every single one of us has always said BaOmer. That one-letter difference is the entire shiur.”

BaOmer Is Present Tense

הַיּוֹם יוֹם אֶחָד בְּעוֹמֶר

“Today is the first day in the Omer.”

The nusach of BaOmer — present tense, immediate

The majority of Rishonim and poskim — including the Mishnah Berurah — rule that the correct nusach is *BaOmer*. Their reasoning: when you count in the morning, the Omer that was brought the night before is still the Omer of today. *BaOmer* refers to the Omer that is currently active, currently in the world.

But there is a problem. On the first night — the night after Pesach — the Omer has not yet been brought. If *BaOmer* requires an already-existing Omer, how can one count on the first night at all?

The Taz raises this difficulty. His answer introduces the distinction between the Omer as a *korban* and the Omer as a *unit of time*. The count does not refer to the barley offering — it refers to the category of time called “the Omer period.” And that period begins at nightfall, before the korban is brought. Hence *BaOmer* refers not to the korban but to the *yemei haOmer* — the forty-nine days of the Omer era.

D'Oraisa or D'Rabbanan?

מִן הַתּוֹרָה אוּ מִדְּרַבָּנָן?

“Is sefirat haOmer Biblical or Rabbinic?”

The great dispute and its consequences

Behind the LaOmer/BaOmer dispute lies a far larger question: is sefirat haOmer today min haTorah or mideRabbanan?

The Torah commands: *usfartem lachem mimacharat haShabbat* — “you shall count from the day after the korban Omer.” The Rambam understands this as a mitzvah d'Oraisa in every generation, regardless of the Beis HaMikdash. But many Rishonim disagree: today, without the Beis HaMikdash, the korban cannot be brought — and therefore the count is merely a rabbinic zecher, a memorial count.

Rav Soloveitchik connects this dispute directly to the LaOmer/BaOmer question. *LaOmer* implies a retrospective reference — counting in relation to an Omer that was brought. That is the language of BaOmer when the Beis HaMikdash stood and the korban was real. *LaOmer*, by contrast, is a softer formulation, appropriate for a rabbinic zecher.

“The Mechaber writes LaOmer. And the Mechaber also holds sefirah today is mideRabbanan. Perhaps the language itself reflects the halacha.”

One Mitzvah or Forty-Nine?

מִצְוַה אֶחָד אוּ מֵי"ט מִצְווֹת?

“Is the Omer count one mitzvah or forty-nine separate mitzvos?”

Rav Soloveitchik’s structural question

Rav Soloveitchik poses a structural question: is the Omer count a single, unified mitzvah — to count a complete seven weeks — or is each of the forty-nine days a separate and independent mitzvah?

The practical difference: if someone missed a day of counting, may they continue counting with a berachah?

If the count is one unified mitzvah, missing a day breaks the mitzvah entirely — there is nothing to continue.

If each day is independent, missing one day is no worse than missing a single push-up in an otherwise completed workout — the remaining days retain their own validity.

This debate maps directly onto our LaOmer/BaOmer question. *LaOmer* — retrospective — sees each count as pointing back at what has already accumulated. Each day builds upon the last. They form a unified whole. *BaOmer* — present tense — is immediate, self-contained. Today’s count is today’s mitzvah.

Two Types of Zecher

זֵכֶר לַמִּקְדָּשׁ – זֵכֶר לַחֲרָבָן

“A remembrance of the Temple — a remembrance of the Destruction.”

Rav Soloveitchik’s distinction, cited by Rav Shechter

Rav Soloveitchik distinguished between two fundamentally different types of zecher. The first is *zecher laMikdash* — mimicking how a mitzvah was performed in the Beis HaMikdash, in order to preserve institutional memory. We do it the same way so we will not forget the way it was done.

The second type is *zecher laChurban* — reminding ourselves of what we are missing, of the wound that has not yet healed. This is not pedagogical preservation; it is mourning.

Which type of zecher is sefirat haOmer today? The Brisker Rav noticed that immediately after we finish counting, we say *HaRachaman hu yachazir lanu avodat Beis HaMikdash limkoma bimheirah veyameinu* — “May the Merciful One restore the Temple service to its place.” We are declaring, in the very next breath, that what we just did was not the real thing. That is the language of *zecher laChurban*, not *zecher laMikdash*.

“The first thing we say after counting is: ‘Restore the Temple service.’ We are saying: what we just did was an imitation of what should have been. That is zecher laChurban.”

Zecher LeMikdash or LeChurban?

הַרְחֵמֵן הוּא יִחְזִיר לָנוּ עֲבוֹדַת בֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ

“May the Merciful One restore the Temple service to its place.”

The post-sefirah prayer — Brisker Rav’s key insight

If sefirat haOmer today is *zecher laMikdash* — a faithful recreation of the Temple-era mitzvah — then we should do it exactly as it was done: with the same confidence, the same joy, the same certainty. *BaOmer* would be the natural language: this is the Omer, now, present, real.

But if sefirat haOmer today is *zecher laChurban* — a reminder of absence — then *LaOmer* is more accurate. We are counting in reference to the Omer that should have been brought, pointing toward something that is not here. The preposition *la* reaches outward, toward something else.

Rav Lebowitz presents this as the Brisker Rav’s deepest insight: the choice of *LaOmer* over *BaOmer* is not merely grammatical preference. It encodes a fundamental statement about what we are doing when we count. We are mourning and hoping, not reenacting. The language itself is a theological position.

The Brisker Solution: Say Both

זֵיכֶר רַב טוּבָהּ יִבְיָעוּ - זָכָר רַב טוּבָהּ יִבְיָעוּ

“Zeicher rav tuvcha yabi’u” — and then again: “Zecher rav tuvcha yabi’u.”

Rav Soloveitchik’s practice in Ashrei — applied to the Omer

Rav Soloveitchik was a man of extraordinary precision in halacha. When he davened Ashrei, he would recite the *zayin* verse twice — once as *zeicher* (with a tzeireh) and once as *zecher* (with a segol) — covering both pronunciations and their respective authorities.

When the dispute between LaOmer and BaOmer came up, Rav Soloveitchik applied the same principle: he counted both ways. He said *hayom yom echad LaOmer* and then *hayom yom echad BaOmer*. By doing so, he was not hedging — he was making a statement: both formulations capture something true about what the count is. The retrospective and the present-tense are both dimensions of the same mitzvah.

This is the Brisker solution in its purest form: when a dispute reflects two genuine truths about a mitzvah, you honor both. The solution is not to pick a side — it is to say both.

“He said the pasuk in Ashrei twice — once zeicher, once zecher. He counted the Omer twice — once LaOmer, once BaOmer. When both are right, say both.”

וּסְפַרְתֶּם לָכֶם

“And you shall count for yourselves.”

Vayikra 23:15 — the mitzvah of sefirat haOmer

LaOmer or BaOmer? The question is not merely grammatical. It asks what kind of act sefirat haOmer is, what it commemorates, and what kind of relationship we have with the Beis HaMikdash in its absence.

Rav Soloveitchik said both. And in that both-ness lies the deepest insight: sefirat haOmer today is simultaneously a reenactment of the living mitzvah and a mourning of what we have lost. It is present and retrospective at once. Every count is a small Tisha B’Av and a small Pesach in the same moment — looking back toward the Temple and forward toward its restoration.

The Brisker chumra is not about being strict. It is about being complete.

About these notes. These shiur notes were prepared by Matthew Miller from the audio recording of Rav Aryeh Lebowitz’s Ten Minute Halacha shiur, “L’Omer or B’Omer?” They are a study aid intended to preserve and share the teachings — not a verbatim transcript.

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